levels of physical fitness. Then came the actual para training itself, the para position and the para roll. How to wear the main and reserve parachutes and how to deal with emergencies. The different kinds of landings, including water landing or in a built-up area. How to exit from the helicopter, first from mock-ups, then from actual helicopters. We were progressively taught to jump and roll from ever-increasing heights, starting from ground level to about four feet, as even with a parachute, that is the kind of impact that has to be absorbed. We were taken up a fifty-foot-high tower and made to look down over the edge to check for any signs of fear or vertigo, and one or two jawans did fail this test. A full dress rehearsal followed, where we wore both the main and reserve chutes, emplaned and went over the dropping zone (DZ). We were made to stand at the edge of the moving helicopter and had to stick one leg out as if actually jumping out. Back on the ground, we were shown how parachutes are sorted and repacked after every jump, right from the airing and drying room to the packing tables. Each parachute is serially numbered and a log is maintained, recording how many 'jumps' that parachute has done and the names of the people doing the packing. Folding and packing a parachute so that it opens smoothly when the ripcord is pulled is a highly skilled job, with the packers acutely conscious that one small mistake on their part may result in a fatal accident.

Finally, the big day dawned for our first jump. There was a mid-term break, so Veena and the girls joined me at Sarsawa to witness the jumps. They, along with other family members, came by road and were taken to the spectators' gallery at the DZ. We trainees went to the tarmac and boarded the waiting helicopters. Each helicopter was carrying two sticks (rows) of paratroopers sitting on the port (left) and starboard (right) side, each of six to seven men and women. As per convention, the

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